



TOM FRANKLIN/Staff

Bringing the birds home to roost: Pat Marcum, director of the Carolina Raptor Center, whose new building is taking shape rapidly at Latta

Plantation Park, examines one of the center's permanent residents, Zinnia, a common barn owl.

Hopes, dreams fly high

Raptor center soon to have new home

By PAT BORDEN GUBBINS
Staff Writer

If the Carolina Raptor Center moves into its new \$220,000 home by April 1, it's going to cost one of its board members a wad of money.

If that deadline is met, Charlotte lawyer Kent Brown has promised to take the entire 12-member board and the center's major donors, Fred and Edna Moretti, to the restaurant of the Moretti's choice.

"And it looks like we're on schedule," said raptor center Director Pat Marcum, as she toured the two-story, 4,000-square-foot building on a recent afternoon.

Brown's challenge is the type of volunteer spirit that has helped the raptor center thrive in tight economic times when other nonprofit groups are faltering.

The success of the new center, at Latta Plantation Park in northern Mecklenburg County, may revolve around something as simple as a love of wildlife.

"I'm just in love with animals, birds of prey in particular," said Edna Moretti, a former volunteer who encouraged her husband to

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Birds of prey have fine friends

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make a \$100,000 donation toward the building.

"I think the raptor center does so much good," she said. "Education is the key. If people had more respect and understanding of animals, they wouldn't do some of the things they did."

Zinnia, a common barn owl, is an example of well-meant but damaging human intervention.

"People got her when she was young and tried to raise her as a pet," said Marcum, holding the exquisitely feathered owl on her arm. "She imprinted on humans, which means she doesn't know she's an owl. They didn't feed her properly, so she developed rickets."

As a result, both wings are deformed. Zinnia could not survive on her own, so she'll live out her life at the raptor center. But she earns her keep in several ways.

She is a valuable teaching tool for the center's educational programs. "And she is a wonderful surrogate mother," Marcum said.

Hundreds of birds

The center took in about 500 birds last year, including orphaned birds that need mothering, and hosts of injured and sick birds in need of medical care. Most are released back into the wild. Unreleasable birds such as Zinnia will remain to educate people about the value and natural splendor of raptors — eagles, owls, buzzards, hawks and falcons.

About 100 loyal volunteers feed the birds, clean their cages, give programs and perform a multitude

of other essential tasks. They include people such as Jim Arthur, a retired vice president of Hoechst-Celanese. He lives on Lake Wylie, a 30-mile drive to the raptor center.

"About 2½ years ago, an associate of mine who was on the raptor center board asked if I'd be interested in being on the board," he said.

Arthur was installed six months after he retired and just as the new building project was being launched. "I was asked to serve as the coordinator of that, and I've been doing it ever since," he said.

On average these days, as the center nears completion, he volunteers about 30 hours and drives at least 300 miles each week.

"He's been just wonderful, making sure everything has been done and on time," said Marcum. "I'd

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